

ANNA SHTOURMAN/FIDE

88
Number of Grandmasters India has so far, latest being Divya Deshmukh

4
Indian women who are Grandmasters. Others being Koneru Humpy, Harika Dronavalli and Vaishali Rameshbabu

◀ **CLINCHING THE WIN** Divya with her FIDE trophy after winning the World Cup in Batumi, Georgia

44
Number of woman Grandmasters globally. Divya is only the eighth to earn the title as a teenager

CHESS GETS ITS 'IT GIRL'

Divya's win, along with Vaishali's in the 2023 FIDE Women's Grand Swiss championship, says Anand, will hopefully "inspire a lot of girls to take to the game". It has certainly infused new energy into chess. As Emil Sutovsky, CEO of The International Chess Federation (FIDE), noted in a chat with ChessBase India recently, "Humpy embodies the tradition of chess—very classy, very reserved, very dedicated—old-fashioned in a good way. Everything that chess has been cherished about. Divya has an absolutely different approach—she is a modern-day social media star." Sharp not only in her play but also in how she presents herself, Divya is referred to as the 'CEO' for her stylish formal wear. A peppy teenager otherwise, she has an aggressive attitude on the board. Her latest win is sure to make her the poster girl for the golden generation of Indian chess.

Grandmaster Abhijit Kunte, who has led India's women's team since 2021, appreciates the Gen Z-ers not just for their talent but also their mentality. "Vantika and Divya have a lot of energy, tantrums and know only their way," he says. "They don't believe that things may not happen. The previous generation always came from an underdog mentality. This generation is tremendously confident, open to experimentation and not afraid of taking risks."

They are also unfazed by the stature and rating of their opponents. For the past two decades, China and Russia have dominated the women's field, with China occupying the top five spots in the FIDE ranking and boasting world champions like Hou Yifan and Ju Wenjun. That gap may now be closing, feels Anand, noting how Divya and Humpy each defeated two heavily-favoured Chinese players to make it to the World Cup finals. "This establishes India as a country that can hold its own against China," said Anand. "The Chinese still have a lot of depth and are the number one country in the women's section, but now we can field a full competitive team. The rivalry will be interesting to watch." One may not have to wait for long, given that both Divya and Humpy have qualified for Candidates 2026, a tough tournament that determines the challenger to world champion Ju Wenjun.

For the moment, though, it is women's chess that is the real winner. In an interview to *Sports Today*, Divya said, "I was very happy when Humpy reached the finals because, for Indian chess, it's a great thing... Whether I win or Humpy wins, Indian girls would take inspiration either way." For Humpy, the GOAT of Indian women's chess and reigning world champion in the rapid chess format, the attention devoted to the FIDE Cup has been heartening and a stark contrast to when she competed. "I have reached the semis and won the bronze four times in this championship, but no one actu-



"Divya's victory is a historic step, a big breakthrough... that too, at such a young age. I hope the extensive attention it has gotten in India will inspire a lot of girls to take to the game"

VISHWANATHAN ANAND
Chess Grandmaster